

The Joy Mechanism: A Hypothesis You Can Test

A mechanism can be testable, coherent, and useful, yet remain unexamined when it falls outside institutional pathways.

This document addresses that gap by proposing a directly testable hypothesis of joy, developed independently and open to critique and transmission. The model predicts abrupt access rather than gradual improvement, and persistence after 48 hours.

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Joy involves a brownish visual tone, chest pleasure, candy-like perceptual textures in response to certain visuals, amplified sensory intensity, and various positive emotions that appear to be linked to olfactory processing.

This proposal is grounded in **control dynamics**. When evaluation is perturbed, while a sufficient level of stimulation is maintained, a durable regime transition may occur.

During the transition (<48h), involuntary laughter and an unusually stable and vivid imaginative capacity may occur. For example, it may become possible to imagine a room filled with flowers with a high degree of realism, and to maintain this mental representation effortlessly. These phenomena are interpreted as possible correlates of regime transition.

After the 48h window, those acute effects disappear and the joy state stabilizes.

1 Minimal Computational Formalization of Joy. Don't worry about it. Go to the game-task directly if you do not care about it.

Let $\delta(t)$ denote prediction error.

Discrepancies are transformed into corrective drives:

$c(t) = g \cdot \delta(t)$ with evaluative gain: $g = g_0 + \alpha \cdot Z(t)$

A regime transition occurs at g^* :

- $g \geq g^* \rightarrow$ error-canceling regime
 - $g < g^* \rightarrow$ sustained salience
- In the permissive regime: $\delta_{\text{eff}}(t) = \int_0^t \delta(\tau) w(\tau) d\tau$, $l(t) \propto \delta_{\text{eff}}(t)$

Z controls evaluative load, and g maps prediction error signals to correction. Reducing Z weakens this mapping, allowing discrepancies to persist as signals rather than corrections and drive intensity. This is not a variant of active inference, it is a regime where the mapping from prediction error to corrective action is weakened below a threshold.

See details at reference: Morin, F. (2026). A Regime Theory of Joy: The Ease Regime as a Permissive Control Configuration. *SSRN*, <https://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6711318>

or at <https://florianmorin.com/papers/regime-of-joy>

2 The game-task: “M-ZRT” for the “Morin Z-Reduction task”

In a FPS, easy-mode, without hud, when optimization is locally suspended, the player can retain immediate control and perceptual intensity **while evaluative load (Z) is reduced**. The FPS task provides a controlled environment that isolates Z while maintaining sensory engagement. The effect follows an inverted **U-shape**: brief, non-instrumental perturbations reduce Z, whereas repetition reintroduces anticipation, comparison, and checking, increasing Z. Therefore, the aim is to reduce optimization, not to replace it. The task should be no more than 60 seconds per day, as a matter of principle.

Exercise	Operation	Z	g	δ	Mechanism
Deviate trajectory	While running, you deviate course for an instant 🌞⌚	↓	↓	introduced + persists	disrupts trajectory optimization and prevents immediate correction
Micro-movement	You perform a small, purposeless gesture (eg: shoulders moves) ⌚	↓ (slight)	↓	introduced	creates a minimal discrepancy without triggering a goal-directed response
Incomplete question	Ask an incomplete or meaningless question (e.g., “what if I?”) but you do not attempt to answer or resolve it 🌞	↓	↓	persists	prevents cognitive closure and blocks conversion into problem-solving
Fading image	Make a mental image, you notice when it fades away 🚀🌞⌚	↓	↓	amplified	leverages transient salience without stabilizing it through control
Suspension phrases usage	“Nothing to solve out right now”, “this is a procedure”, or just “ok”, “Alright” ⌚ without waiting for an effect.	↓	↓	persists	reduces closure pressure while avoiding conversion into a new task
Alcohol (very low dose; a sip)	A very small dose reduces control and monitoring globally ⌚🚀	↓	↓	persists (+ noise)	lowers evaluative load but may reduce signal coherence
Geometric shape	Notice a geometric shape of the décor, corner, corridor, ramp, pillar 🚀	↓ (light)	↓	amplified	perceptual salience without semanticization
Coffee (very low dose, a sip)	Increased arousal raises sensitivity to incoming signals 🚀	~ / ↑	~ / ↑	↑	increases δ without necessarily reducing Z

These exercises fall into three functional classes, **salience** 🚀 (perceptual prominence), **openness** ☀️, and **suspension** ⌚. Some combine multiple mechanisms.

Use up to three items from the table, vary their order each day, and randomly alternate between coffee, nothing, and alcohol. Recommended: not more than 1 attempt at the game-task for every 24h. Low repetition and temporal spacing are used to slow the transition from suspension to optimization within the exercises. Optimization begins when the subject starts to feel that it could be done better, more correctly, or more efficiently.

Possible advices for micro-mouvement and image fading

Micro-mouvement

Make movement amplitudes extremely variable. Do not repeat the same movement pattern between sessions.

Image Fading

Use an ordinary image with little emotional charge. Do not immediately repeat multiple attempts. Do not measure how long the image lasts. Do not force disappearance.

After the game-task

Exercise	Operation	Z	g	δ	Mechanism
Simple faces or jewels 🚀	You observe faces images with clear expressions or gemstones.	↓↓	↓↓	amplified	combines high perceptual intensity with minimal interpretative demand
Music-clip 🚀	Self-selected music-clip.	↓↓	↓↓	amplified	combines high perceptual intensity with minimal interpretative demand

Once an exercise is captured by the monitoring system, it should be considered “dead” for a few days. In some cases, the monitoring system can capture the broader situation itself. The failure mode is not merely local correction, but whole-protocol evaluative takeover. *Seconds fix what minutes and hours destroy.*

3 The Regime-First Logic

The more a stimulus becomes identified as “the source,” the more it recruits monitoring. One must enter the “regime first” logic. It is not the object or the place that makes an experiment good, but the brain configuration currently activated that amplifies everything.

Walking provides a natural context to reduce Z.

Non-special route

At times, take a path that is not meaningful, not the nicest, or not the most promising, without attempting to select the “worst” path either, then continue normally afterward.

Change sidewalk without reason

Switch sides of the street arbitrarily. Not at the “best moment”.

Brief stop and restart

You stop for 1-2 seconds, then resume walking without explaining the interruption. Do not count exactly two seconds. Variants: a) A micro-slowdown rather than a complete stop.

b) After the stop, allow a brief micro-latency before choosing what to do next.

Music. Do not wait for the “right moment” to start music. Do not continuously optimize volume level. Sometimes, stop the music when it starts to become interesting, or briefly look at a neutral detail and let the music continue. Sometimes, stop the music at a neutral moment. Sometimes, when a passage is enjoyable, do not repeat it.

Reading. Shifting between unrelated paragraphs from a book disrupts narrative continuity. Do not try to memorize or understand perfectly.

Time. Look at the time, but do not check it a second time.

In general, act without explaining or justifying what you do, internally or externally. Do not defend internal states.

The simplest route to joy may not be reward maximization, but temporary de-optimization.

If you feel like it, you can send the questionnaire to me at florian@florianmorin.com, no pressure at all.

Yes/No

1. I felt less need to decide what to do next.
2. I felt less need to correct or adjust my actions.
3. Something felt unexpectedly more vivid, pleasant, or engaging.
4. Any change felt sudden rather than gradual.
5. I could not identify a clear cause for any change.
6. The task became a method or strategy.

free-text question: **In a few sentences, describe what happened, especially whether anything felt different, sudden, vivid, pleasant, effortless, or strange.**